Venezuela: Talking Points (Grades 7-8)

Video: about 7.5 minutes. Use these points if the video does not play.

1. Simón Bolívar and independence

- Born in Caracas, 1783. 1810: Venezuelans challenge Spanish rule; 1811: independence declared.
- 1821: Battle of Carabobo secures Venezuelan independence. Gran Colombia joined Venezuela, Colombia, Ecuador and Panama.
- Bolívar is "El Libertador"; Bolivia is named after him.

2. Abolition of slavery

- March 24, 1854: President José Gregorio Monagas signs the law abolishing slavery. About 11 years before the U.S. (1865).

3. Cultural blend

- Indigenous, African and European traditions: arepas, joropo (harp, cuatro, maracas), African drums, Spanish with Indigenous words, mestizo identity.

4. Beauty and resources

- Angel Falls (979 m / 3,212 ft), the tallest waterfall on Earth; Andes and Pico Bolívar; Los Roques; Margarita Island; Orinoco River.
- Largest proven oil reserves in the world (about 303 billion barrels, EIA 2023); gold, iron, cacao.

5. Dictatorship to democracy

- Gen. Marcos Pérez Jiménez fell in January 1958. Democracy from 1958; decades of relative stability funded by oil.

6. Decline under Chávez and Maduro

- Chávez took office in 1999: nationalizations, price controls, concentration of power, close ties with Fidel Castro and Cuba (Cuban advisers in security and intelligence).
- Maduro from 2013: oil output fell about 70% from 2013 to 2023 (EIA), hyperinflation, shortages of food and medicine.
- 2024 election disputed: the opposition published vote records saying it won. UN investigators documented serious human rights abuses.

7. The diaspora

- Nearly 8 million Venezuelans have left (UNHCR, based on government figures); about 7.0 million in Latin America and the Caribbean (R4V, Aug 2026).
- Destinations: Colombia (largest), Peru, Brazil, Chile, and the U.S., especially Florida. Families are separated.

8. Maduro captured

- January 3, 2026: U.S. forces captured Maduro and his wife in Caracas. Indictment in New York (SDNY): narco-terrorism conspiracy, cocaine-importation conspiracy, weapons charges. Pleaded not guilty.
- Legality under international law is debated. Delcy Rodríguez is interim president.

9. María Corina Machado and what is next

- Won the opposition primary (2023); barred from the 2024 ballot; Nobel Peace Prize 2025.
- Returned to Venezuela on October 25, 2026 after almost ten months abroad.
- No official election date. Machado asks for 2027 (a July 24, 2027 date has been proposed); U.S. officials want the Supreme Court and electoral council reformed first. Say: "elections are expected in 2027."

Discussion questions

- What does independence mean, and why did Bolívar fight for it?
- Why do people leave their country, and what do they take with them?
- What makes free and fair elections important?

Sources: Reuters, AP, Congressional Research Service (Jan 2026), U.S. EIA, UNHCR / R4V, World Bank. Prepared Oct 28, 2026.